

Very in-app-ropriate

FOR YEARS NOW, THE DEBATE ABOUT MEDDLING IN ELECTIONS BY ROGUE STATES HAS CONTINUED. And how was the meddling done? Using social media, of course, and the ability to pay money to expose your content to more and more people. That's just how advertising on social media works – the people willing to spend the most money get access to the most people's social timelines.

However, this is all pretty straightforward. It's something that is easy to understand, and the goals are pretty short term. For example, getting someone to win an election... or maybe getting someone to lose an election... to spread positive or negative propaganda against people, companies, groups, races... you name a subset, and they will have a rival group, who could, theoretically, benefit from the downfall of the first subset.

It's not always bad either. Remember Coke vs Pepsi? Often, rivalries are good, and they can be fun. And this is how we view most conflicts – in terms of rivalry. Apple vs. Google, Facebook vs. Twitter, iOS vs. Android, India vs. Pakistan, US vs. Russia, etc. It's not always that simple though.

In the world of digital spying, where data is money, and information is power, everyone wants to get their hands on your data.

No, this is not yet another bashing of tech companies and what they do with your data... I'm not too bothered by what Google knows about me. I am bothered about what a government knows about me. Especially if that government wants to use my data in some way against my country, or another... Governments are not playing a passive role in this data collection anymore – they're not just looking to order a tech company to hand over your data by using legal methods like warrants or legal notices... they're looking to get us to give them our data directly!

Most of us would have come across this idea of government's spying when we read stories about tiny little rogue chips being found on hardware that was made in China. Some US national security officials claimed that compromised server motherboards containing the rogue chip that was smaller than a grain of basmati rice, found their way into Apple, several large US banks, and even government offices, including the department of defense! And this was (allegedly) only discovered when Amazon wanted to buy a certain company that dealt

with these motherboards and hired a third party security company to suss them out.

Of course everyone denies it, especially China, the US, the Chinese manufacturers, Apple and even Amazon, but it's not at all improbable.

Then there was the Russian-made FaceApp (which people went nuts over in 2019, as one of its filters let you see how you'd look as an old person). There were rumours spread about it being a tool used by the Russian government to gather facial recognition data on citizens of other countries – especially Americans. What could Russia do with such data? Who knows, but that didn't stop conspiracy theorists from coming up with ideas. From something as simple as scanning your face to clone and unlock your iPhone, to more sinister plots such as replacing US citizens with Russian spies who had undergone plastic surgery to look just like you... social media was abuzz.

Then there is ToTok, a popular chat app that has been installed by millions in places like the US, Middle East, Africa and Europe, and even by many in Asia. It's essentially a messaging app that works in countries that block WhatsApp or Skype. Recently it was removed from both Google and Apple stores because reports suggested that it was a spying tool of the UAE government.

This is the new reality that we live in, and it feeds off our paranoia in the worst ways possible! For example, Indians are going to automatically be suspicious of anything and everything made in Pakistan or China, because news of rogue apps and hardware puts us on edge. However, such news can also be used by Indian companies to fool us into a false sense of security, or to reduce competition from companies abroad.

In a world where our mobile devices are a gateway to pretty much everything we are (our money, friends, job, identity documents, etc), being super-paranoid about what you install on it is wise. (These companies have got me sounding like Mithun now!) We could just use a method he'd probably recommend... have two different devices for all the different things you do. One with everything important – all your important logins, financials, and your actual email, etc., with only trusted and important apps installed... And the other you can set up with a disposable email, no important accounts, and is just a device you use for fun and games and trying out every new fad... Think you could pull off the strict dichotomy? 



"I'm not too bothered by what Google knows about me. I am bothered about what a government knows about me. Especially if that government wants to use my data in some way against my country, or another..."



Liked or hated this column? Let me know at: robert@digit.in | facebook.com/raaabo | @raaabo | t.me/digitgeek | discord.gg/myD8Xvt | WhatsApp: +91 98211 69631